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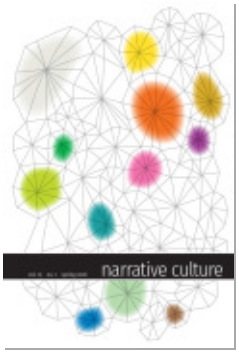
Mistaken for Narrative: A Closer Look at Small Texts

John Laudun



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Mistaken for Narrative

A Closer Look at Small Texts

In *Seduced by Story: The Use and Abuse of Narrative* (2022), Peter Brooks laments the "narrative takeover of reality" in which so many professions and so many industries have convinced themselves that they either already tell or should be telling stories (4). Books like Annette Simmons' *The Story Factor* (2006) promise us narrative ways to win friends and influence people, and those like Matthew Dicks' *Storyworthy* (2018) assure us that just by collecting our own stories in a systematic way, we can deepen our understandings of ourselves. Whether our attention is turned outward or inward, stories would appear to be the key in what Christian Salmon has termed the "*nouvel ordre narratif*" (ix). As both Brooks and Salmon observe, the reason for the interest in narrative is not always benign: it is seen as one way to route around the analytical and/or logical. Why argue with someone if you can sit them alongside you and tell them a story? (The imagistic conventions around storytelling are a feature, not a bug.)

Early assertions have reified into assumptions, and many humanities scholars have joined in the championing of narrative as a primary, if not primordial, way that humans understand the world. When texts are consistently conceived as stories, we attend to them, or fail to attend to them, in ways that at least obscure

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potentially compelling dimensions. The central concern here is to explore the nature of textuality when it comes to the kind of small texts that lack the "tellability" and narrativity that are important features of the Labovian model (see next section; Labov). Alexandra Georgakopoulou has called these texts "small stories," but I wonder if we do not leap to narrative too quickly (36). Is it possible that alternate forms of text creation, like a description or a report, might have equally compelling roles in creating and maintaining identities? An exploration of alternative modes of textuality allows us to map how "we store our experiences of the everyday world as knowledge structures . . . in our minds so that we can refer back to them when we encounter new situations and concepts" (Gavins 22). It is through these texts after all, that we as ordinary individuals negotiate who we are and what we can do or have done. By considering a wider range of modes of discourse in addition to narrative, we open up the possibility that identities and worlds are not only sequenced by time but also by space, perspective, status, and causality.

The goal here is to explore what greater precision in examinations of texts might bring to our understanding not only of those texts and the genres in which they participate, but also in how people negotiate social worlds through texts. Vernacular genres like jokes, personal and historical anecdotes, legends, and even conspiracy theories are often embedded in conversation. Their dialogic nature both creates and reflects an emergent semantic space distributed pragmatically across speakers often seeming to be part of a negotiation of reality and its inherent, probable, or possible events. In doing so, it could be the case that other modes of discourse may not only suffice but may actually be preferred to narrative by performers.[1] In a number of American discourse communities, for example, locative descriptions appear as often as historical anecdotes when talking about the past (Laudun 1999; Richard 2004).[2]

Put another way, narrative is one of many kinds of texts all of us exchange on a daily basis both in the physical world as well as various virtual ones. The focus here is on the relationship between the small passages within a text that we can clearly distinguish as narrative, and the larger texts such passages—along with those that describe, inform, report, and argue—combine to create. While the larger project seeks to understand how narrative emerges as the dominant or structuring mode, here the focus is on a few examples that challenge the assumption that narrative is the preferred mode for a couple of well-known genres of folklore. Without exception, the texts are presented without the larger discursive

context that might reveal how they became texts. The underlying assumption here is from performance studies: some sequences of clauses stick together sufficiently in the minds of participants to be removable from one performance and repeatable or reportable in another performance.

In the exploration that follows I explore how different forms of textuality, beyond just narrative, shape our understanding of communication especially in vernacular discourse. Using two models of texts as symptomatic of a larger set of assumptions about small forms qua folk narrative, I demonstrate their limitations in considering non-narrative forms that are not only a part of traditional vernacular discourse, like locative descriptions and arguments, but are also a part of emergent vernacular discourses. With an eye to the latter, the analysis extends to online discourse specifically using examples from Gab social media posts related to conspiracy theories after the 2020 US presidential election. My goal is to demonstrate how various discourse modes contribute to meaning-making and text repeatability in both oral and digital contexts. This complicates the assumption that narrative is the dominant mode for imbuing discourse with textuality and suggests a more multifaceted view of how texts create compelling "worlds."

Rethinking the Syntagm

There is no room here to discuss all the dimensions of the various discursive, pragmatic, and semantic operations that allow texts as small as several dozen words to create a world that an audience finds a compelling reason to imaginatively enter it. What we are focused on here is the assumption that text-worlds have largely been considered the product of narrative forms, and thus many small texts that may not necessarily be narrative in nature are considered as narrative in some fashion. The best place to start a re-consideration is with the dominant model of narrative for small texts, like those studied by folklorists, linguists, and anthropologists sometimes known as the Labovian model, whose original nature was based on a rather small number of elicited personal experiences.

To be fair, before George Labov and Joshua Waletzky's 1967 seminal paper, "Narrative Analysis: Oral Versions of Personal Experience," the normative model for folk narrative as syntagm was more broadly tale-types as sequences of motifs, or more narrowly, Vladimir Propp's *Morphology of the Folktale* (1968).[3] Pursuing

a similar logic as Finnish folklorist Antti Aarne who had created the original tale-type index in 1910, and American folklorist Stith Thompson who had greatly expanded it in 1928, Propp broke folktale texts into their constituent parts (Aarne; Aarne and Thompson). Unlike Aarne, who was interested in sorting the tales into types, Propp broke off a subset of tales in order to determine the structure that underlays them, in effect, quantifying and qualifying his intuition that they were all the same. To do this, he largely ignored composition as well as any themes noting that: "All *predicates* give the composition of tales; all *subjects*, *objects*, and other parts of the sentence define the theme. In other words, the same composition may lie at the base of various themes" (113). In Propp's view, all stories are made up of one or more such events, and folktales are stories made up of familiar events. Should an event be present across several texts, then it is likely to be a function enabling a higher level of abstraction.

While Propp does indeed discuss subjects and predicates in the conclusions of his work, he offers no method for his abstractions: they are based on insights drawn from the corpus itself. Recognizing that therein lay a gap between the semantic abstraction of "*the hero is recognized*" and what a performer might actually say, Labov and Waletzky pursue a finer-grained analysis of oral narratives that as they note, is "concerned with the smallest unit of linguistic expression which defines the function of narrative—primarily the clause" (13). Like Propp, they focus on a subset of texts drawn from a larger project focused on the linguistic dimensions of social stratification.[4]

In their examination of a small collection of personal experience narratives, they conclude that clauses can be categorized into a discrete number of types and that the clauses regularly appear in a particular sequence. The close attention to observable linguistic phenomena, words and the clauses in which they are ordered, is important here: first because so many observers are prone to move quickly to abstractions and, second, because the impulse simply to state that something is a narrative seems remarkably indefatigable. Labov and Waletzky are interested in narrative sequence the same as the rest of us, but their scope is far finer: the clause is their unit of analysis (12). Their framework assumes that, at least in these personal experience narratives, the preference of both performer and audience is to recapitulate the represented series of events in the same order in which they occurred (20–21). In this way, the verbal sequence has a one-to-one correlation with the source sequence. That is, while syntactic embedding is available in a variety of scribal discourses, the preference in day-to-day, face-to-face

oral performances of personal experience narratives is to stick with the sequence as told being the sequence as it occurred. (As we will see in a moment, this preference for ordinate correspondence occurs across a number of oral genres.)

In the Labovian model, texts are made up of clauses that can be considered "free" or narrative (Labov and Waletzkey 22–25). Free clauses describe a scene or provide information and can be deployed more freely within the sequence of clauses that make up a text without changing the meaning of the text. At the other end are narrative clauses that must proceed in a particular sequence, bonded to each other in a particular order that produces the meaning of the story itself—to change the sequence would be to tell a different story. This ability or inability of clauses to move forward and backward within the overall sequence is considered their "displacement." Free clauses exhibit wide displacement, while narrative clauses exhibit little to no displacement.[5] An example from a collection of Louisiana legends about treasure provides us a useful example: note that I have left the handful of complex sentences with independent and dependent clauses together because for our purposes here, splitting the clauses out adds unnecessary visual clutter. (For more on the collection, see Laudun, "Tallying Treasure Tales".)

EXAMPLE 1: LEGEND IN THE LABOVIAN MODEL[6]

(1) Along with his brother, they went looking for cypress moss for cushioning their pillows and blankets. (2) This was way back in the day. (3) As they were searching, they noticed a stone slab on the ground beneath a tree. (4) It was odd because the husband and his brother weren't able to move the slab of stone. (5) It seemed to be stuck in the ground. (6) Then, they got this weird feeling. (7) Something wasn't quite right with the stone. (8) The two men freaked out, and they climbed the tree in fear. (9) When they looked down, the slab of stone disappeared. (10) They jumped down from the tree and ran home.

While it is not uncommon for anecdotes to feature a number of lines setting the story up, this text proceeds quickly with two lines that clearly must come before the rest, followed by one line that could, in reality, go anywhere but, in most instances of oral performance that I have heard, comes quite early if not at the very beginning of a legend in order to establish that an anecdote with some historical distance is about to be relayed. The introductory clauses (1–3) are followed by two pairs (4–5, 6–7), each pair enacting a semantic echo highlighting

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the changed nature of the story's reality. The first pair gives us the event, and the second pair adds an emotional valence. With the tension built, the text ends with two sentences with embedded clauses that propel the story, and then a final sentence that returns the main characters to where they began.

Those familiar with the Labovian model will recognize that most of the clauses in this short text are narrative, and only one clause (2) is free. In the model, any clause that is locked into a particular sequence with another clause is held in that place by a temporal juncture. In the text above, it is clearly the case that for the story to make sense, the brothers must leave home to look for moss in order to come across a stone slab, and that stone slab is what frightens them and makes them climb a tree before jumping down to run back home. Along the way, the text offers us a couple of clauses which, in effect, repeat the sense of the previous clause. Such repetition of course is a powerful discursive effect, a kind of ideational rhyme, but it does open the door to what happens when the text takes its foot off the narrative gas to spend time in a particular moment.

The model does not stop with clauses; Labov and Waletzky also attempt to describe a larger syntagm that informs the personal experience narratives under examination. The overall structure of such narratives is first an *orientation* that establishes the who, what, when, where of the story. In the legend above, the first two clauses (1–2) establish the characters, the task, and the historical moment. After the orientation comes the *complication* section that conveys a series of events that can often lead to a resolution. In the legend, the complication comes in pairs of clauses (3–8) leading to the resolution of the two characters climbing a tree, the slab disappearing, and them fleeing home in the last two clauses (9–10). Missing from this particular text, but appearing in a range of other texts, is an *evaluation* where performers often remind their audience what the point of a story is. The evaluation is not required but it is often present in more fully developed stories, especially ones that have been told more than once. While many narratives end with the resolution, some narratives reveal the need for the performer to locate the story in the moment of the performance. The *coda* is the label they give to the optional last cluster of clauses that return the discourse to the present moment, shifting the focus of the discourse from the story world to the world in which the story is situated.

Labov and Waletzky's grounding of a story's larger structure in the actual discourse that conveys the story deepens, and perhaps complicates, Propp's syntagm. While Propp's analysis obviously benefits from a more regular set of characters

and features embedded in the texts he examines, the variability of the personal experience narrative drives Labov and Waletzky to arrive at a fairly abstract structure—orientation, complication, evaluation, and resolution—a structure which, if we are being honest, does not seem all that far from Gustav Freytag's 5-level Pyramid of exposition, rising action, climax, falling action, and denouement (114–140).

With Labov and Waletzky's careful attention to the kinds of small texts that have long been the purview of folklorists and anthropologists, and that are now increasingly of interest to information scientists, these studies demonstrate that discursive sequences matter. By and large, however, because the scope of the work was limited to narrative texts, other forms of textuality were not examined: indeed, the Labovian model's clauses are essentially either narrative or free. What this leaves out is the possibility that other syntagms may be part of a speech community's repertoire and that the texts those syntagms produce may have as much semantic force as texts in which narrative is dominant. They may, in fact, produce texts that are still considered, in the emic world of the speech community, to be an anecdote, legend, or conspiracy theory. The reliability of such syntagms is what makes it possible for a string of clauses to be dislodged from one moment of telling and lodged in another, a process that folklorists Richard Bauman and Charles Briggs have termed "decontextualization" and "recontextualization" and what anthropologists Michael Silverstein and Greg Urban have described as "decentering" and "recentering" of a text.[7]

While analysts can make texts out of almost any string of clauses, what interests us here are those forms of textuality that are repeatable and are, in fact, repeated. Repeatability gives us a much clearer sense of what emic conceptions of textuality might be. As those familiar with studies of personal anecdotes are already aware, and which the Labovian model makes quite clear, repeatability applies not only to content but also to form. Thus, some texts function as texts because they represent a conventional form of text-making, of stringing clauses together in such a fashion that an audience can readily recognize the *how* of something being said and focus on what is actually being said. We recognize how a joke begins—"Did you hear the one about . . . ?"—without necessarily knowing anything about the content.

An example will help to illuminate our exploration. The following historical account, which I am reluctant to call an anecdote since anecdote is usually reserved for narrative forms (e.g., personal, local character, historical, etc.), came

out of research I conducted among speakers living in the American Midwest (central Indiana) about a particular event that occurred immediately after the Second World War (Laudun "And There Were a Lot of Families"). What I was struck by again and again were the number of times I heard and documented discourse like this:

EXAMPLE 2: LOCATIVE DESCRIPTION

> People would gather round the old square and sit on the fenders of the old cars and they'd chit-chat for an hour. But the neighborhoods, the families that lived in that area, they'd frequent one grocery store to buy all their groceries. And they'd have a charge account. And you could go in there like on Sunday morning and get a quart of chocolate milk and a dozen donuts and put it on the tab, if you didn't have the money. Or you could buy the Sunday paper. (Laudun, "And There Were a Lot of Families" 52)

If there is any necessary ordering of clauses here, it is purely a function of anaphora: *they* first reference people and then families. (It is replaced by *you* in the last 2 clauses, but the actual reference remains constant: people back then.) There is no necessary temporal ordering here unless you count needing to go into a store first before buying a quart of chocolate milk. Rather, the ordering here is like a camera wandering around a moment in time: people visiting the courthouse square, people shopping for groceries, or someone buying a paper.

This notion of functional, or modal, dominance emerging out of multi-functional, multi-modal discourse deserves more exploration. So many seem to assume that narrative is the preferred mode of imbuing discourse with textuality and concomitantly, projecting a rich world beckoning audiences to enter, but, as the second example above suggests, there is more to vernacular textuality than simply narrative. In my own work, I have found that texts run the gamut from strictly narrative accounts to locative descriptions or even, at times, information or argumentation.[8] Another text from the treasure legend corpus opens the door to a wider form of textuality that we usually imagine:

EXAMPLE 3: TREASURE LEGEND

(1) Right there where the trees is they use to have a house in there. (2) Probably got the mark where the house is now. (3) We used to go in there. (4) We use to hear they had gold there. (5) We'd go try to dig it, couldn't dig, couldn't dig. (6) Me, Dexter, Kenneth, your daddy. (7) Just about all of us, I think Roland too. (8) We all tried. (9) Couldn't. (10) You couldn't even get the shovel in the ground. (11) It's a certain time you could've get it in. (12) But you wasn't finding nothing. (13) And you would hear noise in there. (14) You hear . . . you hear strange noise. (15) There in the trees. (16) Yeah they had some stuff in there. (17) A spirit.

A comparison of the previous example with this one reveals that the narrative nature of the text is a bit blurry. The text offers a chronology but it is not of a particular event, but rather of a *typical* event. As I have argued elsewhere, the inclusion of stative clauses, clauses that represent (or create) generic states and events, are as much a part of vernacular discourse as narrative or descriptive clauses (Laudun, "The Modes of Vernacular Discourse" 414–416). We tend to relegate them to exposition, but as our third example establishes, performers will blend the two forms of discourse to achieve particular pragmatic effects. Here, the performer is an older relative talking with two younger family members who asked if he and others used to go looking for treasure. His response is not about a particular treasure hunt but a compilation of treasure hunts into a generic form suggesting that this was a common occurrence. The text itself enacts this by proceeding through a series of coordinate clause clusters, eventually switching from first person to third person, as if understanding that by making things stative the text has lost some pragmatic force and some repair is needed.

A Closer Look at Conspiracy Theories

So far, we have been looking at texts, legends, and locative descriptions produced through oral discourse: texts that are products of encounters between humans in the physical world. Are the observations made so far—that we need to expand our consideration of vernacular discourse in order to avoid mistaking everything as narrative—equally applicable to online discourse in encounters between humans in the virtual world?

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There is of course no single virtual world, but a vast diaspora of websites and platforms and apps through which people can engage one another as themselves or a persona of their choosing. One such world is Gab, a social networking site that is similar to Twitter/X that allows users to publish posts, initiate private chats, join groups, and livestream. In the moment in which we are interested, just after the 2020 presidential election in the US, Gab, Parler, Twitter/X, and a number of other sites were sites for various kinds of performances by people who had voted for the losing candidate. Gab was both a vessel for banal conversations, communication about events, a conduit for reporting on events and, in some cases, organizing events and actions that led up to and included the insurrectionist mob that stormed the US Capitol.

A few months after that, it was revealed that both Parler and Gab had data backends (the tables of information that contain who posted what to whom on what day and at what time) that were in fact not secure and the data was actually, in many ways, public (Goodin). The data was made available to interested and authenticated researchers. I received permission as well as instructions how to download the Gab archive.[9] I chose the Gab data only because I knew the least about it, and thus my explorations would be of a terra incognita.[10] The download was 70GB and it contained user account names and messages, statuses, and group names (in SQL files) as well as a compilation of the chat logs (a mere 10MB by comparison). The chatlog file contained, according to its internal documentation, "70593 messages in 19683 chats with 15322 users." Each entry contained a date-time stamp, the user, and the message (e.g., "2020-12-22T20:18:32 @OsmanAbbaker: hi"). Having worked with both online and oral materials before, and after some hand inspection of a random sampling of texts, I decided to break the texts into 6 groups with break points at 20, 50, 100, 200, and 500 words. The number of texts for each grouping is in Table 1.

A repeated sampling within each of the 6 groups helped to determine the probable utility of including texts of that size. It quickly became apparent that texts of less than 20 words were largely phatic in nature or contained too few words to offer a discursive sequence (e.g., "it worked ! ! !" or "just checking out the new chat feature").[11] At the other end were texts of 500 words or more, which, as it turned out, were largely full of HTML links. The richer territory for examining vernacular discourse seemed to lie with texts from 20 to 500 words in length. Dropping texts that are less than 20 words as well as texts that are nominally larger than 500 words brought the useful texts in the corpus from the original 70,593 to 17,975.

TABLE 1. WORD COUNTS FOR GAB TEXTS

Word Count	Number of Texts
< 20	47,344
20–50	12,831
50–100	3,742
100–200	1,099
200–500	303
> 500	16

As even the 4 categories of posts of different sizes reveal: there are a wide variety of topics, and of positions and positioning in this material. With such considerations in mind, let us take a look at 3 texts, and 3 conspiracy theories (or legends) from the corpus. The first example is rather more typical of what conspiracy theories on Gab tend to look like than even I was prepared for. Because Gab was, at that moment, still a relatively newcomer to the social media platform landscape, the post is one of quite a number of posts and queries focused on the platforms involved. In posts both large and small, there was a lot of concern about who was on what app as people switched from Twitter/X, which was represented as restrictive, in comparison to Parler and Gab which were figured as "free." As people sought to rebuild, quite literally, their information networks, there was understandably a variety of expressions of anxiety. A lot of this amounts to posts such as "Is X here?" or "Does anyone know how to find X?" There was also a subgenre of posts that address the matter of the platforms themselves, folding the platforms themselves into a conspiracy theory matrix. This post combined concerns about Parler being out of service with not only the then-president working with the in-group's platform (Gab) but also with some sort of papal conspiracy. (More on this in a moment.) The only logic that connects all these events seems to be the one that motivates many conspiracy theories like Qanon:

> It's so evident white hats are behind parler going down. I know you like it there, but this causes me great joy and gives me even more assurance (as if i needed more) that patriots are in control. I fully believe parler is compromised. I also think potus has been working with gab. Post about having a phone call with "someone special" today. Listen to @ post today about "they told us to build our own back in august of 2016." Who is "they?" (That one may be a stretch.) Anyway, parler going down is very exciting to me. :) So are the lights being out at the

> vatican. So is getting to comfort and encourage eleven people in my life today! I'm so grateful to God for using me and making me feel so helpful and alive . My life is amazing. I love it so much ! : -d (Parler user @CrawfishFestival 2021)

This kind of accretive logic is not uncommon among the Gab posts. The principal actors appear to be patriots, the then-president, and the Vatican. The entities at stake are Parler, Gab, and, apparently, the electric grid. (With wires providing both power and information, the conflation seems inevitable, especially in legends.) The structure of the post is difficult to discern: it appears to be a grab bag of ideas asserted in a sequence whose logic appears to be entirely accretive: the more, the better. This style of argumentation is familiar, and it probably deserves a closer examination than we have time for here. If there is a structure, it is something akin to a puzzle being solved with any series of steps that get the job done being acceptable.[12]

Another way to understand the text above is to consider it an example of a report: a text organized not by narrative sequence or by spatial contiguity but by the discourse itself. Clauses in reports still represent entities and events but are connected by the act of speaking. Such reports are not as repeatable as narratives or descriptions perhaps because they are so tied to their own discourse, but they are a form of text-making that, like the personal anecdotes that formed the basis for Labov and Waletzky's study, are recognizable because it occurs regularly. Take for example the following conspiracy theory that is part of a longer dialogue between 2 Gab users in 2021 (the complete dialogue between users CrawfishFestival and DemsFearTruth is available in Appendix A). After some back-and-forth discussion focused on the notion that the Capitol was the site of a crime, the "steal," and that key figures will be "perp walked" and "crying like a bitch" on live television, one user makes the following series of assertions, each on its own line as represented here:

> (1) I saw that Italian authorities ARRESTED Obama's Cybersecurity Chief in Italy, (2) surveilled them from the moment they entered their country. (3) Obama hired him to create the algorithms for the Steal. (4) Election results sent thru server in Frankfurt, Germany were then sent to them in Italy to be manipulated. (5) They also have records of Obama flying pallets of cash to fund THE STEAL, and Bank records of Bank accounts. (6) Flight logs, and CIA operatives involved have been identified. (Appendix A)

The discursive sequence of events being offered is not the same as the actual sequence of events. Re-assembling the text we have, in sum: Barack Obama, who was president when Donald Trump became president-elect but was 4 years out of office by the time of these events, hired his cybersecurity chief to create the algorithms for the "steal" that occurred by having election results sent through Germany to Italy.[13] This was funded with cash flown in on pallets and there is proof in the form of bank records, flight logs, and identified operatives. This sequence occurs if the clauses are placed in the following order: 3, 5, 4, 1, 2, 6. That is a significant divergence between the order of represented events, their order in the representation, and much of the infrastructure that would suggest embedding is absent.

As analysts, we have to decide if there is a story being told here, and if there is, is it being told through narrative or through some other means? I would argue that the story here is a report. It does not begin at the beginning but, rather, begins with the resolution: someone has been arrested. The rest of the text seeks to explain, through the accrual of evidence, and support the claim. In some ways, this particular text might be better imagined as an argument. Such an assertion is not as strange as it might initially seem: a number of conspiracy theory texts, which perhaps I am arguing represents the nature of conspiracy theories themselves, are structured more by the argumentative mode of discourse rather than by the narrative, reportative, descriptive, or even informative modes. Take for example the following post made by a user on January 14, 2021 near the end of the time frame for the Gab corpus. I have broken the post into a series of sentences, some of which are single clauses and some of which have subordinate clauses:

> (1) I have been hearing we are at war. (2) I have heard Chinese ships and submarines are on their way to us. (3) Attorney Lin Wood said we are at war with China and Iran. (4) I have heard from multiple sources that the troops in DC are there because we are at war. (5) That would make sense about all the generators being delivered. (Parler user @CrawfishFestival 2021)

The text begins with a proposition—"we are at war"—that is repeated in the fourth clause with an elaboration. Each proposition is followed by a fact to substantiate it: Chinese ships and submarines are en route and, later, the military presence is why generators are present. Sandwiched between these two

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proposition-fact pairs, there is an appeal to authority: someone has said we are at war.

The Chinese threat is a regular feature in the alt-right imaginary on Gab. (For another example, see Appendix B.) This particular text begins with a thesis (1): *we are at war*. What follows is a series of assertions (2–4) that build a case through compiling a list of very concrete entities (ships, submarines, Lin Wood, troops) to argue for the inevitable presence of generators in Washington, DC. While the un-substantiable fact of generators being present, and they are the telltale sign for this text, it is given that this represents a fact for this particular text that seems to work backwards: generators are present because there are more troops in DC and more power is needed. If there are more troops in DC, it must be because we are at war. If we are at war, it must be with China (and Iran), and, if so, they have sent ships and submarines. It is, of course, a rather extraordinary series of causal relations, but that is because the discourse is actually sequenced as an argument, not as narrative. (That is, one could assemble these clauses in a different order, and they would still argue the point.)

There is, I think, a fuller typology of texts to be enumerated, but they would be particular to a speech community. Elsewhere I have examined Carlota Smith's "Modes of Discourse," and the argument here is that these modes can be dominant in different genres, or, at minimum, they are in the proverbial mix (Laudun, "The Modes of Vernacular Discourse" 411–417). As the consideration of conspiracy theories above demonstrates, not all conspiracy theories are narrative. Rather, some are reports, some are information, and some are arguments. No doubt, as texts get longer, there will be, as Mikhail Bakhtin also noted, a mixture of modes. What future mappings of such phenomena will need to do is to attend to the passages involved and how any one mode comes to be the structuring, or dominant, mode within a given text. It has already been suggested here what some of those modes might be in regard to the subset of legends now called conspiracy theories, but what about local legends? The same applies to anecdotes and other small texts.

It's Not a Narrative World After All

Almost a quarter century ago, Bill Ellis noted that "fragmentary, incoherent plots are the norm rather than the exception among legends" when treating legends as a performance (9). My suggestion here has been that these texts should not

be considered fragmentary but rather simply products of different discourse processes (modes) that produce different text-types than that of narrative. Not all texts wish to be stories, and if they do not wish to be a story, it is quite possible that they will seek a non-narrative shape, one based in description, information, reporting, or argumentation. Allowing texts to be what they are should drive us to understand those texts *as they are*, rather than how we wish them to be. Such a drive will lead to greater precision in our description of vernacular texts and perhaps even make it possible to develop a better map of vernacular discourse.

The focus of this work has been small, vernacular texts, the kind we exchange every day in dialogues had online and off. The implications for larger forms are yet to be explored. As humans build bigger and bigger texts out of passages various in nature, it is probably the case that some modes will dominate, but how such construction occurs might be worth a closer look. The idea that large forms are built out of small forms is not new, of course. In his later work, Bakhtin distinguished between what he called "primary and secondary genres": primary genres are the spoken forms that have long made up the way humans have interacted and secondary genres include not only obvious literary forms like novels and plays but also nonfiction forms like scientific research, legislative and judicial records, and the myriad of other complex forms that constitute modernity as we know it. He is also quite clear on the relationship between the two: secondary genres are built out of primary genres: "during the process of their formation, they absorb and digest various primary (simple) genres that have taken form in unmediated speech communion" (62). Moreover, Bakhtin asserts, even the simple genres are made up of smaller pieces taken from everyday utterances. The very kinds of conversations in which we all engage on a daily basis become the basis for dramatic dialogues within jokes and anecdotes.

Such an approach might seem antagonistic to a recent trend to composite texts when working with large data sets, such as the Gab corpus. This work usually proceeds by first compiling common actants (e.g., merging the president, President Biden, Biden, the White House, etc.), then their actions and the objects of their actions, into a composite network of subjects acting on objects from which individual narratives, or "fragmentary, incoherent plots" are drawn. Such an approach was an early part of how folklore was studied—look no further than nineteenth century attempts to re-assemble the great epics of various nations (e.g., Finland's Kalevala). The idea of an *ur*-narrative, which survives only as fragments in later periods, somewhat like a clay pot survives as shards, has largely been abandoned,

but we maintain the idea in things like the tale-type or the kernel of a narrative.[14] In some of these efforts to work at scale, there is a balance to be struck, as Tim Tangherlini et al. note:

> Our methodology is predicated on the underlying structure of the narrative framework that captures how a storytelling instance emerges via a collective negotiation process. Each post to a forum describes relationships among only a subset of actants (which are not yet known to our automated algorithms). (8)

If we replace *storytelling* with *discursive*, I think we might have something closer to the ground truth of these texts. Whether the composite results in a narrative framework or some other kind of framework is not something that this essay can explore let alone determine. Rather, my effort here is focused on making it clear that at the level of performance, at the level of the text itself, not all texts are narrative in nature. Opening up how such frameworks or networks are constituted is, I think, central to understanding how cultures are organized and how they respond to changes in the environment.[15] Put another way, there is an enormous opportunity here to understand the relationship between text-types, their concomitant text-worlds, and the networks of ideas, actants, and actions which they constitute.

Moreover, this approach also reinvigorates a suggestion that Dell Hymes once made with regard to the difference between the performance of a text and a report of it. As readers familiar with his essay on a "breakthrough into performance" will remember, the shift from a report of a Native American Wasco narrative into its performance involved not only code switching but also an animation of the voices concerned (90). While the shift in language can be glimpsed textually and the change in voicing cannot, there are perhaps other indices to which we can attend. For example, given the kind of flattening effected by the choice to use statives in the treasure legend of the third example, might it be better considered an example of a report? At the very least, the idea of *reference* needs to be re-examined and perhaps even find a place in our considerations of vernacular texts. It introduces the possibility of a schema that would allow us to distinguish between some fuller version of a text, a partial rendering, or a kind of thumbnail. With such a schema in place, we could begin to explore how much of a larger text-world or narrative network is carried by any particular instance.

I do think there are implications for the relationships between microstructures, like passages and small stories/texts, and macrostructures, like literary prod-

ucts such as novels and legal statutes, and even the kinds of analytical fictions, like "metanarratives" and "cultures." Taking it down a notch, or three, from grandiose ramifications, a lot depends on how we define narrative, or, perhaps, where we locate narrative. If we locate narrative in discourse, then it is clear that there are a variety of forms of text-making which do not rely upon the kind of one-to-one sequencing of events to their representation that lies at the heart of most considerations of narrative.

Appendices

APPENDIX A

2021-01-03T23:45:09 @DemsFearTruth: Yeah, I think Trump is going to arrest a bunch of people on the 6th . . . Like US Marshals roll into the House and Senate and perp walk Pelosi type thing.

2021-01-04T05:14:19 @CrawfishFestival[P]: I hope so. President Trump said, It is going to be WILD.

2021-01-04T05:40:37 @DemsFearTruth: I cannot think of anything wilder than when Pelosi pisses herself, and Schumer cries like a bitch on live CSPAN while being handcuffed.

2021-01-06T05:51:40 @CrawfishFestival[P]: WILD, for sure.

2021-01-06T05:53:35 @CrawfishFestival[P]: I saw that Italian authorities ARRESTED Obama's Cybersecurity Chief in Italy, surveilled them from the moment they entered their country.

2021-01-06T05:56:01 @CrawfishFestival[P]: Obama hired him to create the algorithms for the Steal. Election results sent thru server in Frankfurt, Germany were then sent to them in Italy to be manipulated.

2021-01-06T05:58:25 @CrawfishFestival[P]: They also have records of Obama flying pallets of cash to fund THE STEAL, and Bank records of Bank accounts.

2021-01-06T05:59:07 @CrawfishFestival[P]: Flight logs, and CIA operatives involved have been identified.

2021-01-06T17:11:15 @DemsFearTruth: none of this will matter if Biden ends up in the WH.

2021-01-07T09:09:58 @CrawfishFestival[P]: That's what former LEOs told me, too.

2021-01-07T09:11:29 @CrawfishFestival[P]: What about US Military—w everyone taking $ from our enemies = Communist China?

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2021-01-07T13:24:39 @DemsFearTruth: It's over. Trump surrendered last night.
2021-01-07T18:17:37 @CrawfishFestival[P]: He did not say "concede", just "orderly transition".
2021-01-07T18:19:13 @DemsFearTruth: yeah, his staff is quitting left and right . . . it's over.
2021-01-07T18:21:06 @CrawfishFestival[P]: What about Ukraine having international arrest warrants for their Criminal investigation w Burisma Scandal, plus. . . .
2021-01-07T19:31:14 @DemsFearTruth: Who here is going to prosecute it?
2021-01-07T19:31:22 @DemsFearTruth: Nobody.
2021-01-07T19:31:53 @DemsFearTruth: No more than he was punished for SEAL Team Six.

APPENDIX B

@REDCOORS9: Id ask for help but 100% of people where I am are Chinese, obv.
@DYKSTRA89: brutal. get away from those chicom agents
wild
VICTORY OR DEATH KILL THEM ALL
pence on the run lmao
@REDCOORS9: Capitol has been breached
@DYKSTRA89: pentagon denying requests for national guard at the capital.
LOLOL
dude im watching it all, is wild
theyre in pelosis office going through her email
@REDCOORS9: You know way more than me. Updates. Just got back to car
completely dead
@DYKSTRA89: trump confirmed pence is a total cuck. senate and house evacuated through their underground pedophile tunnels
people funneling into the capital , just chaos. police seem to be standing down at this point
@REDCOORS9: Where we just were but I was to
Dead. Walked min 50 miles on no food
Just went by a caravan of cia big boys
Trump's a faggot loser. Flynn or sidney 24
This is so goat. Torba floor level based. I still have a racing heart for 20 mins

after we get back, driving for 10 and still yelling at these faggots about how cares how it looks.

John Laudun is the UL Federal Credit Union/BORSF Endowed Professor of English at the University of Louisiana, where his research focuses on qualitative and quantitative models of discourse, especially narrative, and how those discourses cascade through socio-cultural networks both online and off. For more: https://johnlaudun.net.

■ NOTES

1. I prefer performer here over speaker because some of the texts under consideration here were transmitted and received digitally. I also prefer performer here over user because it calls attention to the dynamic nature of these interactions: they are dialogic in nature. That is, people perform for others, perhaps in different ways, in both actual and virtual spaces.
2. From the point of view of contemporary narratology that has advanced the notion that the feeling of being there, or *qualia*, is a feature of narrative modes of discourse, this suggests that other modes are capable of this as well. This runs counter to David Herman's claim that "we cannot even have a notion of the felt quality of experience without narrative" (145).
3. In attempting to understand why a subset of Alexander Afanasyev's *Народные Русские Сказки* (*Traditional Russian Tales*) seemed so similar, Propp isolated 100 tales from the larger collection of 600 east Slavic and Russian fairy- and folktales in order to determine what was constant and what was variable. Antti Aarne compiled his *List of Fairy Tale Types* (1910) based on texts he culled from other collections. His list of "tale types," with its sense that there were common motifs that repeated across narrative types, was revised and codified by American folklorist Stith Thompson into *The Types of the Folk-Tale* (1928). The tale-type index, as it is known among folklorists, "catalogues some 2500 basic plots from which . . . European and Near Eastern storytellers have built their tales" for at least a few hundred years (Ashliman). (Note that Propp's *Morphology* was published the same year as Thompson's *Types*.)
4. Labov and Waletzky based their understanding on materials drawn from 600 interviews with individuals primarily in urban environments in the northeastern

US (32). The speakers involved were White and Black, rural and urban, ranged in age from 10 to 72 years old, and had not finished high school. Labov and Waletzky's thesis was that "by studying the development of narrative technique from children to adults, and the range of narrative techniques from lower class to middle class speakers, it will be possible to isolate the elements of narrative" (12). Subsequent work has tended to label this as "natural narrative," with the implication being that more educated speakers will have unnatural (literary) influences (see Johnstone). The natural narrative approach became so embedded in contemporary narratology such that some scholars sought to "contest . . . the mimetic bias" (Mäkelä 462). In contrast to this particular intellectual history, the position staked here is that non-narrative forms have their own access to mimesis and create other kinds of text worlds worth examining.

5. There is a third category of clause in Labov and Waletzky's scheme, the restrictive clause, but the essential point of their scheme is that narrative clauses are fixed in relationship to each other and may not be re-ordered without changing the meaning of the story.
6. Please note that in those examples where attention is given to individual clauses, those clauses are numbered.
7. Bauman and Briggs note that the focus on text and context as discursive processes is "signaled grammatically in the addition of affixes that effectively move the emphasis from product to process and from conventional structures to agency as the terms entextualization and contextualization gain currency" (67). Silverstein and Urban describe what they call the "natural history of textuality" as, first, "a decentering of a discourse so as to yield a sufficiently autonomous text, and a recentering of such a text in another discursive context" (15).
8. Following Carlota Smith, I distinguish 5 modes of discourse: descriptive, narrative, reportative, and argumentative. Both narrative and reportative focus on specific events, but while narrative organizes by temporal order, reportative organizes by discursive sequence. Description, like narration, represents specific events but through spatial, not temporal, contiguities. Information and argumentation focus our attention on generic states and generic events, diminishing the role of time as represented and focusing on the time of the representation, the discourse itself. (For more, see Laudun "The Modes of Vernacular Discourse"; Smith.)
9. Ars Technica reported the leak on March 1, 2021 (https://arstechnica.com/information-technology/2021/03/gab-the-far-right-website-has-been-hacked-and

-70gb-of-data-leaked/). The contact point for the data was Distributed Denial of Secrets (https://ddosecrets.com/).

10. A description of the data set can be found on the Distributed Denial of Secret site (JaXpArO). Other scholars have used the same data set to develop the Gab Hate Corpus, which annotates 27,665 posts using "a coding typology derived from a synthesis of hate speech definitions across legal, computational, psychological, and sociological research" (Kennedy et al.).
11. Please note that all lowercase letters is a product of the code I used and not, necessarily, indigenous to the Gab community. Because computers are very bad at things like words, you have to normalize any text such that "The" and "the" are seen as the same thing. Lowering the case for all words is simply one of the fastest, least computationally involved, way of doing that.
12. A number of commentators have remarked upon the puzzle-solving nature of conspiracy theories (Pierre; Thompson).
13. "Stop the steal" became a slogan for individuals who believed the 2020 election had in some fashion been rigged or otherwise tipped in the favor of Trump's rival, Joe Biden. Such claims were largely undermined by Trump's own staff, who repeatedly protested that the election was secure. This did not stop the spread of conspiracy theories like this one. For a blow-by-blow account of events, see Bowden and Teague.
14. In the case of the latter, it should be noted that in her original definition, Susan Kalčik notes that: "Most often a kernel story is a brief reference to the subject, the central action or an important piece of dialogue from a longer story. In this form one might say it is a kind of potential story, especially if the details are not known to the audience. It might be clearer to call this brief reference the *kernel* and what develops from it the *kernel story*" (7; italics in original). This workaround of a reference to a story still somehow being a story have long deployed in the notion of the kernel narrative, the story which is referenced and, in being referenced, is made available to participants as something like a story. I am not so sure that the thumbnail is the same as the larger entity, and the degree of similarity required to invoke the reference text and its text-world is something to which we should pay better attention.
15. In my own attempts to apply the subject-verb-object (SVO triplet) model to forms like legends and folk histories, I have been relatively surprised by the ambivalence within these forms with regards to their reliance on narrative as the local structure.

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